Building a Metrics Dashboard for Search

How a PM turns scattered data into a single source of truth — and drives search performance at an online travel company.

PREPARED BY

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01 · THE CONTEXT

A leading travel company, flying blind on search.

The Search team owns the most critical surface of the product — but they're making decisions without a clear view of how it actually performs.

THE SITUATION

Data is manual, scattered, and slow. Decisions rely on anecdote, not evidence.

THE PRESSURE

A working prototype must be presented to the Product Lead in one week.

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The goal isn't to build a prettier spreadsheet — it's to make the right decision in five minutes, not five days.

THE CORE INSIGHT

From business goal to dashboard, in six moves.

01 · START

Business goal

Help users find and book travel faster. Everything else must serve this.

→

02 · DEFINE

Success

Better search → more bookings → more revenue. A clear chain of causality.

→

03 · ASK

"How do I know?"

This question is the engine. Every metric must be an answer to it.

→

04 · APPLY

Four lenses

KPI · Engagement · Revenue · Operational. Skip one, create a blind spot.

→

05 · CUT

Ruthlessly

Keep only metrics that would change what the team does next.

THE LITMUS TEST FOR EVERY METRIC

"If this number moved, would I act differently?"

Four lenses for a complete picture.

LENS 01

Key Performance Indicators

"Is search working overall?"

The headline numbers that give a top-of-funnel view of search health. The north-star lives here.

LENS 02

User Engagement

"How are users behaving inside search?"

Behavioural signals — clicks, filters, sessions — that explain why KPIs move.

LENS 03

Revenue

"Is search making money?"

How effectively search converts user intent into bookings and commercial value.

LENS 04

Operational

"Is the infrastructure stable?"

Latency, uptime, errors — the technical foundation that everything else rests on.

The five metrics Prerana tracks first.

01 · SEARCH VOLUME

4.2M

Queries per week. The baseline health signal —

02 · ZERO-RESULT RATE

6.2%

Searches returning nothing. High rate signals

03 · AVG. RESULTS/ QUERY

42

Listings shown per search. Signals the right

04 · REFINEMENT RATE

19.7%

Users who re-search immediately. A quiet

NORTH STAR · 05

3.8%

Search-to-book rate. Every other KPI exists to explain movements

Figures are from the Wanderlust Travel prototype dashboard · Weekly view

Search health and user behaviour.

METRIC	CATEGORY	WHY IT MATTERS
Search-to-Book Rate	KPI	North-star conversion metric — did the search journey end in a booking?
Zero-Result Rate	KPI	High rate signals inventory gaps or poor query parsing — a failed experience.
Avg. Results per Query	KPI	Signals whether search surfaces the right breadth of relevant options.
Click-Through Rate	ENGAGEMENT	Measures result relevance and how attractive listings are to users.
Filter Usage Rate	ENGAGEMENT	Users actively refining intent — a sign of healthy, purposeful engagement.
Search Refinement Rate	ENGAGEMENT	High rate quietly flags poor initial relevance — users keep re-searching.
Mobile & Voice Share	ENGAGEMENT	Directional signal showing where to invest next in the search experience.

What search earns and how stable it stays.

METRIC	CATEGORY	WHY IT MATTERS
Revenue per Search	REVENUE	Efficiency metric linking every search query to the revenue it generates.
Avg. Booking Value	REVENUE	Tracks revenue quality, segmented across flights, hotels, and packages.
Upsell Attach Rate	REVENUE	Measures how well contextual recommendations drive add-on revenue.
Cost per Acquisition	REVENUE	Efficiency of spend per booking — falls as search quality improves.
Search Latency P95	OPERATIONAL	Slow search directly drops click-through and conversion. Core SLA: <500ms.
System Uptime	OPERATIONAL	Reliability metric — every minute of downtime is measurable lost revenue.
Search Index Freshness	OPERATIONAL	Stale index means inaccurate pricing and availability shown to users.

The prototype: one screen, the whole story.

✈ Wanderlust Travel — Search Team Metrics Dashboard

LAST 7 DAYS · WEEKLY VIEW

KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS

Search Volume	Search-to-Book Rate	Zero-Result Rate	Click-Through Rate
4.2M	3.8%	6.2%	28.4%
▲ 8% vs last wk	▼ 0.3pp	▼ 1.1pp improved	▲ 2.1pp

REVENUE & OPERATIONAL

Revenue / Search	Search-Driven Revenue	Latency P95	System Uptime
Rs.4.12	Rs.18.6M	320ms	99.94%
▲ Rs.0.31	▲ 12%	▼ 15ms improved	▲ 0.02pp

What this case study demonstrates.

01 Metrics serve decisions, not dashboards.

The discipline isn't listing every measurable number — it's choosing the few that change what the team does next. Every metric earns its place by answering: "Would this change my action?"

02 A four-lens framework prevents blind spots.

KPIs, engagement, revenue, and operational metrics each reveal something the others miss. Tracking revenue alone could hide a search experience that's silently failing real users.

03 A dashboard is a communication tool, not a data dump.

Arrangement matters as much as the data. Leading with the north-star metric and grouping by lens turns raw numbers into a story a leader can act on in under five minutes.

THE THROUGH-LINE

How better search pays off the business goal.

PRODUCT

Better search experience

→

PRODUCT OUTCOME

Users find and book faster

→

BUSINESS OUTCOME

Higher revenue · Lower CAC · Happier customers

Don't measure what's easy to track — measure what's hard to ignore.